

Is vs ought



Hume's scepticism about the role of reason in our decision-making (see [Reason is the slave of passions](#)) extended to his views on moral philosophy. He remarked that in the writings of most moral philosophers, there is a sudden shift from objective description to subjective prescription: the writer jumps from statements using 'is' or 'is not' to propositions using 'ought' or 'ought not'. The change, in his opinion, needed explanation, and given his view that reason alone did not give grounds for certainty, deriving an 'ought' from an 'is' was not a justifiable basis for forming moral judgements. The 20th-century British philosopher A.J. Ayer agreed with

Hume, arguing that this 'naturalistic fallacy' does no more than show how the writer feels about a statement. Ayer's theory of emotivism, or the 'boo-hurrah theory', shows that moral propositions may look like statements of objective fact, but are actually subjective. When someone says 'Murder is wrong', it is really an emotional appeal for the response 'Murder? Boo!', while 'Philanthropy is good' really means 'Let's hear it for philanthropy! Hurrah!'.